

Estate Manager — User Manual

A guide to the **day-to-day usage** of the Estate Manager rental management system — signing in, working with the screens and completing the common tasks you perform every month.

Related documents

- [CONFIGURATION.md](#) — starting the app, user accounts, SMS/email integrations and system settings.
- [DEPLOYMENT.md](#) — putting the system online for demos (Render).
- [TROUBLESHOOTING.md](#) — what to do when something doesn't work.

Table of contents

- [Quick reference — manual vs. automatic](#)
- [Using the app on a phone](#)
- 1. [Signing in](#)
- 2. [The dashboard](#)
- 3. [Properties](#)
- 4. [Units](#)
- 5. [Tenants](#)
- 6. [Onboarding — moving a tenant in](#)
- 7. [Rent payments](#)
- 8. [Reports & the rent ledger](#)
- 9. [Lease renewals](#)
- 10. [Water & electricity bills](#)
- 11. [Notifications message history](#)
- 12. [Activity & audit trail](#)
- 13. [Deleting records safely](#)
- 14. [The Visitors page \(admins\)](#)

The *left-hand sidebar* contains every section (on a phone it becomes the **bottom tab bar** — see [Using the app on a phone](#)). Admin accounts also see a **Users** and a **Visitors** tab — see [CONFIGURATION.md](#) for managing accounts, and [The Visitors page](#) for site traffic.

Quick reference — manual vs. automatic

You do these manually

Task	Where
Sign in / sign out, change your password	Sidebar
Add / edit properties, units, tenants	Corresponding pages
Onboard a new tenant (tenant + lease + occupy in one step)	Onboarding page
Record rent payments	Rent Payments / a unit's row
Enter meter readings (water & electricity)	Utilities page

Mark utility bills paid	Utilities page
Send a renewal notice or renew a lease	Lease Renewals page
Delete / vacate any record (reason required)	Delete / Vacate buttons
Configure settings & integrations	Settings page (see CONFIGURATION.md)
Manage user accounts (admin only)	Users page (see CONFIGURATION.md)

The system does these automatically

Task	Details
Create & seed the database on first run	3 properties, 48 units + sample data, <code>admin/admin123</code>
Send renewal reminders	Runs at server start and every 6 hours ; targets active leases expiring within the look-ahead that haven't been notified yet
Skip already-notified leases	<code>notice_sent</code> is flagged once a reminder goes out — no duplicates
Compute consumption & bill from readings	Previous vs. current reading × rate
Include pending utility balances	Added into rent-due and renewal-reminder messages
Calculate the +10% renew rent	Applied when you click Renew +10%
Compute the rent ledger (expected vs. paid vs. outstanding)	Rent Payments → Load ledger
Totals & report breakdowns	Weekly/monthly summaries + per-property + drill-down
Log every action to the audit trail	Who, what, when and why (incl. reasons)
Mask stored secrets	SMS key / email password shown as <code>....</code> — never returned

Integrations — automatic vs. manual

Integration	Automatic	Manual
SMS — Africa's Talking	Renewal reminders are sent automatically (every 6 h) to every due tenant who has a phone on file (once SMS is enabled in Settings)	Configuring username/API key/sender in Settings; sending a rent-due notice or a test message
Email — SMTP	Renewal reminders are sent automatically to every due tenant who has an email on file (once Email is enabled in Settings)	Configuring SMTP host/port/credentials in Settings; sending a rent-due notice or a test message

M-Pesa	None — M-Pesa is not connected to the system	You record each M-Pesa payment manually in Rent Payments (same as Cash / Bank); the system does not link to M-Pesa or reconcile automatically
---------------	---	--

How notifications flow: a reminder/notice is attempted on **every channel the tenant has** (phone → SMS, email → Email). Channels that are disabled or unconfigured fall back to **simulated mode** (recorded, nothing actually sent) — see [CONFIGURATION.md → Simulated mode](#). The only automatic sender is the renewal-reminder engine; rent-due notices and test messages are always triggered by you.

Using the app on a phone

The system is **mobile-friendly** (a progressive web app — PWA). Everything works in the phone's browser, and on screens narrower than ~760px the layout adapts:

- **The menu is a bottom tab bar.** The left-hand sidebar moves to a horizontal row of icon + label buttons fixed at the bottom of the screen. **Swipe the bar left/right** to see all the sections; the active one is highlighted.
- **Tables become cards.** Below ~600px every table row stacks into its own card with the column name next to each value (e.g. `Rent/month — KES 8,500`), so nothing needs a sideways scroll.
- **Install it like an app (optional).**
 - *iPhone/iPad (Safari):* open the site → tap **Share** → **Add to Home Screen** → **Add**. It appears as an app icon that opens full-screen, without the browser bar.
 - *Android (Chrome):* tap the **:** menu → **Install app**.
 - Installing needs the site served over **HTTPS** — the deployed demo ([DEPLOYMENT.md](#)) is.

I see only the dashboard — where are the menus? If the site looks like the desktop version (or the bottom tab bar is missing), Safari may be loading it in **desktop mode** or showing a stale copy. In Safari tap **aA** → **Website Settings** → turn **OFF "Request Desktop Website"** → **Done** → reload. If it still looks stale, clear the site's data: **Settings** → **Safari** → **Advanced** → **Website Data** → delete the site.

1. Signing in

1. Open the web app (see [CONFIGURATION.md](#) → Starting the app) and enter your **username** and **password**.
2. Click **Login**.

Your **role** (admin or manager) decides what you see and can do — see [Users & roles](#).

Changing your password

1. Click **Change password** in the bottom-left panel (under your name).
2. Enter your current password, then the new one (6+ characters) and confirm.

Logging out

Click **Logout** in the bottom-left panel. Logins and logouts are recorded in the [Activity](#) trail.

Automatic logout (idle timeout)

For safety, the system signs you out automatically after **3 minutes without activity** (any click, keypress, tap, scroll or swiping). You'll be returned to the **Sign in** screen and can log straight back in. The server session also expires a maximum of **12 hours** after login regardless of use.

2. The dashboard

The dashboard is a one-glance overview:

- **Total units, Occupied** (and **vacant**) units
- **Expected rent/month** — from all active leases
- **Collected this month** — payments received this month, and the **% of expected**
- **Outstanding this month** — rent not yet paid
- **Pending utility bills** — total unpaid water & electricity amounts
- **Recent payments** — last 12 payments (type to filter; **View all** opens Rent Payments)
- **Lease renewals due** — leases expiring in the next 60 days (type to filter; **Manage** opens Lease Renewals)

Click any card's **View all / Manage** button to open the full section.

3. Properties

A **property** is a building or estate block with its own units (e.g. *Melon Park, Block 13, Block 3*).

Viewing & searching

- The table lists every property with its **location, total units, occupied** and **vacant** counts.
- **Search property / location...** — type to filter as you go.
- **All / Has vacancies / Fully occupied** — show only properties with vacant units, or only full ones.
- **Clear** — resets all filters.

Adding a property

1. Click **+ Add property**.
2. Enter the **Name** (required) and **Location** (optional).
3. Click **Add property**.

Editing & deleting

- **Edit** — change the name or location, then **Save changes**.
 - **Delete** — see [Deleting records safely](#). Deleting a property also deletes all its **units, leases, payments and meter readings**.
-

4. Units

A **unit** is a rentable space inside a property (e.g. *A1, 13-04*). It is either **occupied** (has an active lease) or **vacant**.

The table

Shows property, unit number, type, current **tenant** and contact, **rent/month**, lease end date, and **status**.

Searching & filtering

- **Search unit / tenant / phone...** — text filter.

- **All properties** — restrict to one property.
- **All statuses** — Occupied or Vacant.
- **Clear** — resets everything.

Compact chips above the table summarise occupancy per property (e.g. `Melon Park: 32/32`).

Adding a unit

1. Click **+ Add unit**.
2. Choose the **Property** and enter a **Unit number** (both required).
3. Set the **Type**, **Monthly rent**, and **Status**.
4. Click **Save unit**.

Occupying a unit (moving a tenant in)

1. Click **Occupy** on the unit's row.
2. Complete the onboarding form (see [Onboarding](#)) — tenant, start date, rent, renewal frequency.
3. The unit is marked occupied and a lease is created.

Vacating a unit (moving a tenant out)

1. Click **Vacate** on the unit's row.
2. Read the confirmation (it shows the current tenant and lease end date).
3. **Enter a reason** (required) and confirm.
4. The active lease ends, the tenant stays on record, the unit becomes **vacant**. The action appears in the [Activity](#) trail.

Deleting a unit

Deleting a unit removes it and all linked leases, payments and readings — see [Deleting records safely](#).

5. Tenants

A **tenant** is a person renting (or who has rented) a unit.

The table

Shows name, phone, email, **active leases** and **total leases**. Tenants with linked leases cannot be deleted (the Delete button is disabled).

Searching & filtering

- **Search name / phone / email...** — text filter.
- **All tenants / Has active lease / No active lease** — status filter.
- **Clear** — resets.

Adding & editing

- **+ Add tenant** — add a person ahead of a move-in.
- **Edit** — update a tenant's stored details.

New move-ins normally go through [Onboarding](#), which creates tenant + lease + occupancy in one step.

6. Onboarding — moving a tenant in

The **Onboarding** page handles move-ins in one form: it creates the tenant, the lease and marks the unit **occupied**.

Open **Onboarding** in the sidebar → **+ Onboard new tenant**. The form has three parts:

1. **Pick a unit**

- **Use an existing vacant unit** — choose from the dropdown (rent hint is pre-filled). If nothing is vacant, tick **Create a new unit**.
- **Create a new unit** — pick the property, enter the unit number and type.

2. **Tenant details** — full name (required), phone, email.

3. **Lease terms**

- **Date of joining**
- **Lease duration (months)**
- **Initial rent (KES/mo)**
- **Renewal frequency (months)** — how often the lease renews; this drives the automated renewal reminders.

A preview box confirms the duration, rent and renewal frequency before you save.

Click **Occupied — save tenancy**. A success card shows the created tenancy (tenant, unit, from-to, rent, renewal frequency). The unit is now occupied and reminders for this lease are scheduled automatically.

Onboarding refuses an already-occupied unit.

7. Rent payments

The **Rent Payments** page records and searches all rent income.

Recording a payment

1. Open Rent Payments (or use **Receive payment** on a unit's row on the Units page).
2. Choose the **unit/tenant**, enter the **amount** (KES), the **date**, and the **method** (Cash / M-Pesa / Bank / other) with optional notes.
3. Save — the payment appears in the ledger and reports.

Searching & filtering payments

- **Search tenant / unit / phone...** — free text.
- **Property, Unit, Tenant** drop-down filters.
- **From / To** dates — restrict to a window.
- **Clear** — resets. A **filtered total** card shows the sum of the current view.

Editing & deleting

- **Edit** on a row — change amount/date/method/notes.
- **Delete** — requires a reason (see [Deleting](#)).

The rent ledger

Below the payment list: **Rent ledger** card.

1. Choose the **from** and **to** months (defaults to this month and 6 months back).
2. Optionally restrict to a **property** and search for a **tenant**.
3. Click **Load ledger**.

Each tenant row lists one column per month with the **expected** rent, **paid** and the **outstanding** balance (shown in red). Totals for expected / paid / outstanding sit at the end of each row.

8. Reports & the rent ledger

The **Reports** page shows income collected across the estate.

Weekly or monthly

Use the **Weekly / Monthly** toggle.

Filtering

- **Date range** — two date/month pickers (e.g. 2026-09 → 2026-11).
- **All properties /** — restrict to one property.
- **Apply** — reload the report.

Reading the report

- **Total collected** — the grand total for the chosen window.
- **Bars** — one bar per week/month; click a bar to load that period's transactions.
- **Table** — transactions count and total per period, with a **Detail** button per row.

Period breakdown

The **Breakdown** card (from a bar or the Detail button) shows:

- the period total,
 - a **By property** split (payments + amount per property),
 - every **transaction** (date, property, unit, tenant, method, amount).
-

9. Lease renewals

Every lease has an **end date** and a **renewal frequency** (months). The Renewals page tracks what's coming up.

Sections

- **Overdue renewals** — leases past their end date.
- **Due within 60 days** — renewals approaching, showing the new (+10%) rent.
- **All active leases** — every current lease.

Rows show property, unit, tenant, phone, current rent, **end date**, days left, whether the **notice** was sent, and the **new rent (+10%)**.

Actions per lease

- **Send notice** — sends/records the renewal notification (see [Notifications](#)).
- **Edit** — adjust dates or rent.
- **Renew +10%** — creates a new lease starting the day after expiry with a **10% rent increment**, using the lease's renewal frequency. The old lease is marked *renewed*, the unit rent updates, and reminders reset for the new lease.
- **End** (terminate) — ends the lease now and marks the unit vacant (tenant stays on record).
- **Del** — permanently deletes the lease record (reason required).

Manual tenancy creation

+ **New tenancy** assigns a vacant unit and an existing tenant with dates and rent — the fallback when Onboarding isn't needed.

10. Water & electricity bills

The **Utilities** page manages meter readings for water (m³) and electricity (kWh).

Recording a reading

1. Pick **Water** or **Electricity**, then the **unit**.
2. Set the **reading date** and enter the **current reading**.
3. The **rate** is pre-filled from settings (editable per reading).
4. The preview shows the **previous reading**, **consumption** and computed **bill**.
5. Click **Save reading**.

The system compares against the previous reading for the same unit and utility, and computes consumption and the bill automatically. A reading lower than the previous one is rejected.

Managing bills

- **Mark paid** — a pending bill becomes paid.
- **Edit** — change the rate or status.
- **Del** — remove the reading (reason required).

Searching readings

The **Readings history** table filters by:

- **Search unit / property...** (text)
- **All properties / All utilities (Water|Electricity) / All statuses (Pending|Paid)**

*Pending utility balances are included inside the **rent-due** and **renewal-reminder** messages sent to tenants.*

11. Notifications message history

The **Notifications** page shows every SMS/email message the system has recorded, with its delivery status.

Each row shows:

- **Time** sent, **Channel** (SMS / Email), **Kind** (reminder / rent due / test)
- **Recipient, Tenant / Unit**
- **Status** badge — `sent`, `simulated`, or `failed`, plus the provider message ID

Click a row to expand the full **Subject** and **body**.

Filtering

- **Search recipient / tenant...**
- **All kinds** — Reminder / Rent due / Test
- **All statuses** — Sent / Simulated / Failed

Summary cards

Count messages by **status + channel** (e.g. `4 simulated SMS`).

► **Run automated reminders now** triggers the reminder pass on demand; automatic reminders run on their schedule (see [Configuration](#)).

12. Activity & audit trail

The **Activity** page is the chronological audit log of major actions by every user.

For each entry: **When**, **User**, **Action** (e.g. `login` , `create` , `delete` , `record_payment` , `renew` , `reminders`), **Entity** (e.g. `payment #123`), **Reason** (always present for deletes) and **Details** (amounts, units, names).

Filtering

- **Search user, action, entity, reason...**
 - **All action types** — restrict to one action type.
-

13. Deleting records safely

Every delete requires a reason. This protects records and keeps a complete audit trail.

1. Click the **Delete** (or **Del**) button.
2. A confirmation dialog describes exactly what will be removed.
3. **Enter a reason** (required) — e.g. *"Tenant vacated"*, *"Data entry error"*, *"Rent payment recorded twice"*.
4. Confirm.

The reason, user, time and affected record are stored permanently in the [Activity](#) trail. The same rule applies to **vacating units**.

Deletes are immediate and permanent — there is no recycle bin. Deleting a property or unit removes all linked leases, payments and readings.

For user-account administration (creating users, roles, disabling accounts), see [Users & roles](#).

14. The Visitors page (admins)

The **Visitors** tab (admin accounts only) shows who has been opening the site and how often — useful for checking whether tenants, agents or partners are actually visiting your portal, and for demo day.

Every time someone loads a page in the browser, that single page-load is recorded — this page carries no tracking scripts, cookies or third-party analytics; it only reads the requests the browser already makes. What is stored is minimal: the page opened, the IP address the request came from, the browser/device type and the time. A **Visitors** tab does not appear for, and `/api/visits` is blocked for, manager accounts.

The page shows:

- **Summary cards** — *Total page loads*, *Unique visitors* (counted by IP) and *Last 24 hours*.
- **Daily views (30 days)** — a bar chart of page loads per day, with the number of unique visitors on hover.
- **Top pages** — the 10 most-opened pages with their load counts.

- **Recent visits** — the latest entries with **When, IP, Path, Device** (phone / tablet / desktop / bot) and **Browser**.

Pagination on long tables

Most lists in the app (units, tenants, payments, renewals, utilities, notifications, activity, users and visits) are **paginated**: they show **20 rows per page**, and when there are more you get < **Prev** and **Next** > buttons plus a “1–20 of 157” counter **above and below the table** — either set of buttons navigates every page of the list. Searching, filtering or clearing filters always returns you to **page 1**.